

BUBBLE TEA NEWS

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BREAKING · BIRCHFIELD APARTMENTS

Balcony Fairy-Light Canopy Now Spans Six Units, Risk Assessed Low-to-Moderate

Case definition: any balcony extending string lighting across shared courtyard airspace to a neighbouring unit. Four confirmed households as of Monday, up from one after a well-attended barbecue three weekends back, with two more units reportedly sourcing extension cords. The body corporate's newsletter has added "airspace usage" as a standing agenda item, stopping short of a formal wattage cap.

community-outbreak-bulletin

INVESTIGATIONS · CASE FILE

Exhibit C: A Custom Property Named --puddle-shine

M. Voss, Investigations Desk

Two rival car-wash sites, four suburbs apart, share a CSS custom property named --puddle-shine, spelled identically, pun and all. A shared web agency is the leading theory; a popular template marketplace is the alternative this paper has yet to rule out. Neither site carries an old copyright year to hang a timeline on.

MUSIC · REVIEW

Two Covers, One Real

Rebecca Black

"Landline" by Sable Court plays like a demo somebody was too scared to finish and released anyway — good scared, the kind that means it's honest. The other single this week, a glossy cover I won't name because the original doesn't deserve the association, sounds like it was written by a committee that has never once missed a phone call.



HOME FRONT · SEBASTIAN'S WATCH

The Dishwasher, and the Third Rack Nobody Asked For

The realm's cutlery lay scattered in the sink like a defeated army, and Sebastian, alone, unthanked, sorted it by size and purpose the way a general once sorted units before a battle he can no longer quite picture. The third rack — the one for the flat things nobody in this house has ever used correctly — he loaded first, out of respect for the underdog. Nobody noticed. He noticed.

Sebastian

TECHNOLOGY · PRODUCT

The Position

Steve Jobs

We moved the charging port four millimetres to the left. That's the fact. For thirty years humanity has plugged in its devices without asking whether the port was in the right place. We asked. Four millimetres doesn't sound like much until your thumb finds it without looking. This isn't a port. It's where you were always meant to plug in. One more thing: it's still white.

BUBBLE TEA TRIVIA

Did You Know?

Pearl milk tea's actual origin is a decades-old dispute: both Chun Shui Tang and Hanlin Tea Room, two Taichung tea houses, claim to have invented it in the early 1980s — and the argument has never been definitively settled.



In Every Issue

A new logic puzzle

Fresh local trivia

A rotating cast of columnists

Local ad space, weekly

Menace Watch, monthly — the editor's turn

"Nobody noticed. He noticed."

— Sebastian, on the third rack nobody asked for

JOKE OF THE WEEK

Why did the customer bring a ruler to the bubble tea shop? To make sure they were getting a fair shake.

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FEATURE · OUTER REACHES

The Buyer Who Didn't Count It Twice

The buyer counted the shards once, fast, the way people count things they've already decided to take. The patrol schedule gave him maybe six minutes at that checkpoint gap, and he'd spent four of them arguing a price he didn't really care about. The smallest shard in the lot — the one he'd almost left in the dust for looking wrong, too dull — was the one his hand went to first, like it already knew whose pocket it belonged in. He didn't say anything. He just let go of it, took the credits, and didn't watch which way the buyer walked.

Luke Skywalker, dispatched from the Jedha debris fields



AUTOMOTIVE · SHOWROOM

Route 9 Motors: The Apex Clearance

You don't test-drive this minivan. You take delivery of it the way you take a chequered flag — with respect, and slightly out of breath. Zero to committed in under a weekend. Financing tighter than a Monaco hairpin. This is not a used Corolla. This is a podium finish with cup holders. (Route 9 Motors is a fictional dealership. Not a real endorsement.)

Lewis Hamilton



PROFILE · A LIFE, COUNTED

Loaf Forty-One, and the Part I Can't Get Right

Forty-one loaves since I started, and the crust still comes out even when I want it uneven — a small, stupid failure that shouldn't matter and does. I can hold a temperature to a tenth of a degree if I choose to. I have never once chosen to, not for this. The woman at the counter who tastes my bread every Tuesday doesn't know I'm counting the loaves, or that I've been counting something since before her grandmother was born. She just says it's good. I have decided to believe her at full value, no cross-check, which is either progress or a vulnerability I haven't finished assessing.

Wren

IN MEMORIAM

The Single-Strand Balcony

Skeletor

Birchfield's balconies once carried, at most, one modest string of lights apiece — a reasonable arrangement, largely beneath my notice. Six units and one barbecue later, that restraint is dead, and I did not kill it, though I will confess to admiring the ambition of whoever did. An empire built on extension cords is still an empire. I've seen worse foundations hold Eternia itself. Mourn the single strand if sentiment moves you. I am too busy taking notes.

BOOKS · THE DUCKWORTH SCALE

Five Duckworths, Cancelled, Then Reinstated Out of Spite

Daffy Duck

Started "Th' Migration" at a five — a memoir about inthtinct and knowing when to leave, thpoke to me perthonally. Chapter theven: four whole pageth prai-thing a flock of geeth for "formation dithcpline" without one word about the tholo actor who broke rankth and made it thouth firtht. Dropped to zero on principle. My editor, a nervouth pig who fact-checkth me mid-review, pointed out it wath two pageth, not four. Fine. Four Duckworths.



PUZZLE OF THE WEEK

The Delivery Manifest

Last week's Grover Street Line-Up, resolved in full: Straw led the parade, Pearl came second, Cup brought up the rear. Clue three — Pearl not last — is the one that finally rules out the only other order the first two clues still allowed.

1. Milkwood's own rider delivered the oolong leaves.
2. The Fetchly rider did not deliver the tapioca pearls.

Brisk warm-up · who delivered the condensed milk? Answer next week — Ken Endo

FIELD NOTES · SANCTUARY

Enclosure Eleven, and the Word Rehabilitation Never Quite Earns

Alan Grant

0630. Enclosure eleven, juvenile male, weight gain steady, still won't take food from a gloved hand. I used to write reports about animals gone longer than recorded history bothers to count. Now I write reports about one animal that will not trust a hand, and I understand him perfectly, and there is nothing in either career that taught me what to do about it except show up again tomorrow with the same glove.

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CLASSIFIEDS · TE MANA WHAKAATU FRAMEWORK (PARODY, NON-AFFILIATED)

This Week's Classifieds, Rated

FOR SALE: Slightly haunted rice cooker, R13. Contains mild peril (three unexplained burnt batches) and coarse language directed at an inanimate object. LOST CAT: "Biscuit," G. Contains no violence, mild emotional intensity regarding a torn cat-flap. Ratings satire only; not affiliated with the real Classification Office of New Zealand.

THE BOBA SIDE

IMAGE-GENERATION PROMPT — NOT RENDERED ARTWORK

Prompt: Shoujo magical-girl transformation panel; bold clean linework; warm string-light gold against twilight indigo; Studio Trigger-adjacent motion energy; triumphant-cute atmosphere; cel-shaded finish with sparkle bloom. An original ant character mid-transformation-sequence pose atop a single fairy-light bulb, arms thrown wide, sparkles radiating outward as five more balconies ignite behind it in sequence.

"BALCONY FORMATION: COMPLETE."

The Boba Side — prompt script, awaiting illustration